PA 384D: Public Management

The University of Texas at Austin
Lyndon B. Johnson School of Public Affairs
Spring 2026
Class Time: Wednesdays, 9:00 am-12:00 pm
Classroom: SRH 3.314

Course Instructor: **Kellen A. Kane, Ph.D., MPA (he/him/his)**,
Assistant Professor of Instruction

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- Book Office Hours through https://drkellenkane.youcanbook.me/
  - Can be online or in-person in my office! You will indicate your preference on this form.
- Zoom link for online office hours: https://utexas.zoom.us/j/3541593984?omn=84361454910

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*Per my right, I prohibit the carrying of handguns in my personal office. Note that this information will also be conveyed to all students verbally during the first week of class. This written notice is intended to reinforce the verbal notification and is not a "legally effective" means of notification in its own right.

What is PA 384D: Public Management?

This course will introduce students to the fundamentals of public management. The course will emphasize the role of public managers and their relationships with clientele groups, the legislature, the executive, and the public. The course will introduce theories of administrative accountability, organizational behavior, decision making, and political oversight that help students understand the complexities of the modern administrative state.

Managing in the public sector entails an understanding of the interaction between three distinct dimensions—administrative structures and processes, organizations and their cultures, and the skills and values of individual managers. Public managers must produce results that citizens and their representatives expect from their government while balancing these concerns within a constitutional scheme of governance. Another purpose of the course is to show how the challenges of public management vary across different organizational and policy settings.

What will I learn in PA 384D: Public Management?

1. Students will be able to understand and appreciate the history, study and practice of public management.
2. Students will gain an appreciation for the role of public managers in a democratic society and be able to critically evaluate trends, challenges, and opportunities in the field of public management.
3. Students will demonstrate skill in evidence-based reasoning from identifying the appropriate data or evidence necessary to construct a convincing argument.
4. Students will be able to apply theoretical knowledge to contemporary political issues and problems and be able to identify, propose, and evaluate alternative solutions.
5. Students will be able to formulate, propose and advocate possibilities for positive change in the administration of public programs.

What are the required materials?

This course uses a primary textbook and a set of online articles. You are not required to buy the textbook, and any student who prefers the hard copy will be able to check it out in the UT library free of charge. Otherwise, all textbook readings are scanned and uploaded as PDFs to Canvas. The amount of required reading varies each week, and you are strongly encouraged not to fall behind in the assigned readings. Please note that I reserve the right to and may assign additional reading material during the semester.

- **Public Management, Thinking and Acting in Three Dimensions 2nd edition. Hill & Lynn, Jr., 2016.** In our Course Calendar, this text is referred to as "H&L".
- Other required readings will be posted on Canvas.

How will I learn?

Teaching Modality. This course is synchronous and in-person. To accommodate the scheduling of any potential guest speakers or lectures, I reserve the capability to designate specific class meetings as virtual. Any potential virtual meeting will be announced well in advance to provide students ample opportunity to secure proper space and equipment to join the class virtually. Students are expected to complete the assigned readings and modules before the class. We will then cover the lecture and students will engage in discussion and exercises relating to weekly content.

Communication. The course Canvas site can be found by navigating to the course page via your Canvas Dashboard. Please email me through Canvas. You are responsible for ensuring that the primary email address you have recorded with the university is the one you will check for course communications because that is the email address that Canvas uses.

Asking for Help. Your success in this class is important to me. If aspects of this course prevent you from learning or exclude you, please let me know as soon as possible. Together, we can develop strategies to meet both your needs and the expectations of the course. I will have weekly office hours to allow students to seek

help on individual assignments, general guidance, or other areas of support. You do not need a class-related reason to meet with me. I am happy to connect with you on any topic!

Required Devices. There will be various days throughout the term in which students will be required to have access to a laptop or tablet to complete in-class assignments like exams and synchronous activities. These days when electronics will be required will be designated on the Course Calendar.

What are the assignments in this course?

Grade Component	Course Points	Due Date
Attendance and Participation	15%	
Public Management Journals	15%, total	Wednesday, February 11, 2026 Wednesday, March 4, 2026 Wednesday, April 15, 2026
Case Study Leadership	15%	
Case Study Peer Review	5%	
Public Management Simulation	10%	In-Class Simulation: Wednesday, March 11, 2026 Reflection Due: Wednesday, March 25, 2026
Federal Agency Analysis Project		
Part 1: Agency Purpose, Programs, and Stakeholders	10%	Wednesday, February 4, 2026
Part 2: Agency Public Communications	10%	Wednesday, February 25, 2026
Part 3: Agency Burden Reduction	10%	Wednesday, April 1, 2026
Part 4: Agency Personnel	10%	Presentation: Wednesday, April 22, 2026 Report: Saturday, May 2, 2026

Detailed assignment instructions will be available on the course Canvas page well in advance of the assignment due date. Brief assignment descriptions for all major assignments are included at the end of the syllabus. **Unless otherwise stated, assignments are due by the start of class on the assigned day**.

How will grades be assigned?

Typically, you will be provided a numerical grade upon receiving feedback. Numerical grades will be translated to letter grades using the rubric below:

Grade	Overall Percentage Range
A	94% - 100%
A-	90% - 93%
B+	87% - 89%
B	84% - 86%
B-	80% - 83%
C+	77% - 79%
C	74% - 76%
C-	70% - 73%
D+	67% - 69%
D	64% - 66%
D-	60% - 63%
F	<60%

Note: Lower grades can be earned. I round up grades, so you need to earn a 93.45 to get an A. I rarely round up more than this.

Course Calendar

Class #	Date	Topic	Readings	Discussion Questions and Case Studies	Assignment Due
1	Wednesday, January 14, 2026	Course overview; assignment overview; student expectations	• Syllabus and Assignment Descriptions		
2	Wednesday, January 21, 2026	Three Dimensions of Public Management	• H&L Chapter 1	• Discussion Questions: ○ H&L Chapter 1; Questions 2 & 4	
3	Wednesday, January 28, 2026	Structure: Accountability and Whistleblowers	• H&L Chapter 2 • Golden (2000).What motivates bureaucrats to resist top-down control under an administrative presidency?. Chapter 7	• Discussion Questions: ○ H&L Chapter 2; Questions 4 & 6 • Case Study Presentation: ○ H&L Chapter 2	
4	Wednesday, February 4, 2026	Structure: Constitutional Checks and Balances	• H&L Chapter 3 • H&L Chapter 4 • Moynihan (2024). A Bipartisan Group of Government Experts Warn about the Risks of Schedule F.	• Discussion Questions: ○ H&L Chapter 3; Questions 5 & 8 • Case Study Presentation: ○ H&L Chapter 3	Federal Agency Analysis Part 1
5	Wednesday, February 11, 2026	Regulations and Citizen Engagement	• H&L Chapter 7 • Bhargava (2015). Engaging Citizens and Civil Society to Promote Good Governance and Development Effectiveness	• Discussion Questions: ○ See Canvas • Case Study Presentation: ○ H&L Chapter 7 **Financial Crisis of 2008 (p. 230-236)**	Public Management Journal 1
6	Wednesday, February 18, 2026	The Administrative State and Contracting Out	• H&L Chapter 5 • Petersen et al. (2018). Is Contracting out of Public Services still the Great Panacea? A Systematic Review of Studies on Economic and Quality Effects	• Discussion Questions: ○ H&L Chapter 5; Questions 2 & 4 • Case Study Presentation: ○ H&L Chapter 5	
7	Wednesday, February 25, 2026	Performance Management	• H&L Chapter 6 • Andersen and Nielsen (2020). Learning from Performance Innovation • Gilmore and Lewis (2006). Does Performance Budgeting Work?	• Discussion Questions: ○ H&L Chapter 6; Question 3 • Case Study Presentation: ○ Goodyear (2015). The NYPD's Biggest Problem Might Actually Be an Overreliance on Numbers ○ Radin (2015). Baltimore: When Good Intentions Bring Negative Consequences.	Federal Agency Analysis Part 2

Class #	Date	Topic	Readings	Discussion Questions and Case Studies	Assignment Due
8	Wednesday, March 4, 2026	Strategic Planning and Evidence Building *Guest Speakers:* -Daniel Culotta, Assistant Director of Budget and Organizational Excellence, City of Austin -Jon Soileau, Budget and Performance Manager, City of Austin	• Bryson and Alston (2011). Part 1 • Tama (2017). How an agency's responsibilities and political context shape government strategic planning: evidence from US Federal agency quadrennial reviews • Office of Evaluation Sciences. Evidence Act Toolkit. Sections 1 and 2.		Public Management Journal 2
9	Wednesday, March 11, 2026	Simulation: Evidence-Based Decision-Making in the Midst of Conflict	• Owen and Kauffmann (2015). The End of a Diversity Policy? Wake County Public Schools and Student Assignment CASE. • Carlson et al. (2019). Socioeconomic-Based School Assignment Policy and Racial Segregation Levels: Evidence from the Wake County Public School System		
	Wednesday, March 18, 2026	No class; Spring Break			
10	Wednesday, March 25, 2026	Administrative Burdens and Cutting Red Tape	• Benish et al., (2024). Types of administrative burden reduction strategies: who, what, and how.	• Discussion Questions: ○ See Canvas • Case Study Presentation: ○ Lasky-Fink & Linos (2024) Improving Delivery of the Social Safety Net: The Role of Stigma	Simulation Reflection
11	Wednesday, April 1, 2026	Digital Government	• Recoding America—Introduction & Conclusion • Rik Peeters (2023) Digital Administrative Burdens: An Agenda for Analyzing the Citizen Experience of Digital Bureaucratic Encounters • Moynihan et al (2022) Matching to Categories: Learning and Compliance Costs in Administrative Processes	• Discussion Questions: ○ See Canvas • Case Study Presentation: ○ Moynihan et al (2024) Digital governance, algorithmic decision making, and administrative burdens: The Australian Robodebt program	Federal Agency Analysis Part 3

Class #	Date	Topic	Readings	Discussion Questions and Case Studies	Assignment Due
12	Wednesday, April 8, 2026	Leadership, Culture, and Representation	• Gooden Chapter on Social Equity in PA • Riccucci Chapter on Representation in PA & podcast summary • Jacobsen et al., (2021) Can Leadership Training Improve Organizational Effectiveness?	• Discussion Questions: ○ See Canvas • Case Study Presentation: ○ Headley & Wright (2020). Is Representation Enough? Racial Disparities in Levels of Force and Arrests by Police	
13	Wednesday, April 15, 2026	Flexible working time for final group project			Public Management Journal 3
14	Wednesday, April 22, 2026	Final Presentations			
15	Saturday, May 2, 2026	Final Exam Period (No formal meeting)			Federal Agency Analysis Part 4

Additional Policies and Items to Note:

Sharing of Course Material. No materials used in this class, including, but not limited to, lecture hand-outs, videos, assessments (quizzes, exams, papers, projects, homework assignments), in-class materials, review sheets, and additional problem sets, may be shared online or with anyone outside of the class without explicit, written permission of the instructor. Unauthorized sharing of materials promotes cheating. The University is aware of the sites used for sharing materials, and any materials found online that are associated with you, or any suspected unauthorized sharing of materials, will be reported to Student Conduct and Academic Integrity in the Office of the Dean of Students. These reports can result in initiation of the student conduct process and include charge(s) for academic misconduct, potentially resulting in sanctions, including a grade impact.

Content warning. Our classroom provides an open space for the critical and orderly exchange of ideas through discussion. Some readings and other content in this course will include topics and comments that some students may find offensive and/or traumatizing. I'll aim to forewarn students about potentially disturbing content, and I ask all students to help to create an atmosphere of mutual respect and sensitivity.

Artificial Intelligence. There are several evolving generative AI technologies at our fingertips. These technologies can be used as tools or as weapons. I hope that students are empowered to learn how to employ them responsibly and ethically as well as to become familiar with their strengths (e.g. ideas generation, summarizing), weaknesses (e.g. garbled and often incoherent writing), biases (e.g. reproduction of stereotypes), and flaws (e.g. hallucinations, incorrect citations). Students are allowed to use advanced automated tools (artificial intelligence or machine learning tools such as ChatGPT or Dall-E 2) on assignments in this course at the prewriting (e.g. identifying references) and editing/revising stages (e.g. grammar tools, thesauri, and diction monitoring) of writing assignments in this course, if and only if, this use is properly documented and credited. For more information on my expectations on acceptable uses of AI, please consult our Canvas page.

Academic Integrity Expectations. Students who violate University rules on academic misconduct are subject to the student conduct process. A student found responsible for academic misconduct may be assigned both a status sanction and a grade impact for the course. The grade impact could range from a zero on the assignment in question up to a failing grade in the course. A status sanction can include a written warning, probation, deferred suspension or dismissal from the University. To learn more about academic integrity standards, tips for avoiding a potential academic misconduct violation, and the overall conduct process, please visit the Student Conduct and Academic Integrity website at: http://deanofstudents.utexas.edu/conduct.

Absences. Attendance is expected and crucial for student success in the course and is factored into your course grade. If you face circumstances that would require you to miss multiple class sessions, please contact me so we can determine what accommodations are available.

Religious Holy Days. In accordance with UT Austin policy, you must notify me of your pending absence for a religious holy day as far in advance as possible of the observance date. If you must miss a class, an examination, a work assignment, or a project in order to observe a religious holy day, you will be given an opportunity to complete the missed work within a reasonable time after the absence. For questions regarding religious accommodations, please contact the Office of the Dean of Students.

Notice of Academic Accommodations from Disability and Access (D&A). The university is committed to creating an accessible and inclusive learning environment for students with disabilities consistent with university policy and federal and state law. Please let me know if you experience any barriers to learning so I can work with you to ensure you have equal opportunity to participate fully in this course. If you are a student with a disability, or think you may have a disability, and need accommodations please contact Disability and Access (D&A). Please refer to D&A's website for contact and more information: http://disability.utexas.edu/. If you are already registered with D&A , please deliver your accommodation letter to me as early as possible in the semester so we can discuss your approved accommodations and needs in this course.

Late Assignments: Assignments, exams, and quizzes are due at a specified time. I am willing to accommodate only exceptional circumstances if the student made arrangements in advance and the exceptional circumstances are *well documented*. This means that students should get in touch with me days – not hours – before the assignment is due. In fairness to everyone, you should turn in your assignments on time, as additional time is a luxury. Assignments turned in after the deadline *but within three days* of the due date may receive partial credit. Exams are unable to be turned in late.

Re-grading: I will gladly take another look at assignments that students feel are not graded fairly if students approach me about it in my office hours or appointment. I will only do this over 24 hours *after* the grades are returned. The purpose of this waiting period is to give you a chance to really think about the graded item and consider your response. Students must type up a justification for why they believe the score should be different. If I feel the assignment was graded unfairly, I'll change the grade in the student's favor, but I also reserve the right to lower the grade upon reading if, after reevaluation, I think the student received too high a grade. This system is designed to minimize frivolous grade appeals and to ensure that you have carefully examined and reflected on the quality of your work before deciding to initiate a grade appeal. It is also to ensure fairness to all students by ensuring equitable grading standards across students.

Additional University Policies and Resources for Students: For additional information on UT Policies and Resources for Students, please see the Canvas supplement to UT syllabi.

Important Safety Information

Carrying of Handguns on Campus

Students in this class should be aware of the following university policies related to Texas' Open Carry Law:

- Students in this class who hold a license to carry are asked to review the university policy regarding campus carry.
- Individuals who hold a license to carry are eligible to carry a concealed handgun on campus, including in most outdoor areas, buildings and spaces that are accessible to the public, and in classrooms.
- It is the responsibility of concealed-carry license holders to carry their handguns on or about their person at all times while on campus. Open carry is NOT permitted, meaning that a license holder may not carry a partially or wholly visible handgun on campus premises or on any university driveway, street, sidewalk or walkway, parking lot, parking garage, or other parking area.

Assignment Descriptions

Public Management Journals. Throughout the course, you will be presented with discussion questions either through our course text or through our supplemental readings. This assignment is designed to provide structure and discipline to your interactions with our material and course discussions, as well as opportunities to learn from your interactions with your colleagues. Students will reflect on the key insights from the class (lecture & small group discussions) AND respond to the assigned discussion questions. Your entries should be approximately 300-400 words per chapter/entry for each of the 2 sections (reading reflection & class reflection) but this will likely vary week to week.

Case Study Presentation and Peer Review. Most weeks, we will engage in a case study discussion based on case studies presented at the end of Hill and Lynn, Jr. chapters or other readings. The goal of the case studies is to improve your ability to think about a complex scenario and present a short and concise analysis of this situation. In groups, you will present one of the case studies. Each team will prepare and lead ONE case presentation and complete a peer review for another presentation. Both will be submitted for a grade. You are encouraged to be creative in presenting your case.

Public Management Simulation. You will be presented with a public management dilemma and assigned a role in a class simulation. We will conduct a mock school board hearing, and I will ask the board members to decide on a controversial issue on which many community members and politicians disagree. You will also complete a short reflection after our in-class simulation.

Federal Agency Analysis Project. You will be working in a group to study a federal agency of your choice. Parts of the project will be due throughout the semester so that you don't wait until the last minute to complete the project. For your team project, you will be assigned to work with two other students. Being in a group entails additional coordination costs, but it has benefits: you can divide up and peer-review each other's work, and it generally results in a more thoughtful analysis. The groups are expected to be self-managed, but we will ask all group members at the end of the semester to confidentially assess one another.

- *Part 1: Agency Purpose, Programs, and Stakeholders.* You will develop an informational brief that outlines the key characteristics of your chosen agency. You should approach this brief as if you were providing instructional material for new cohorts of agency personnel orienting around the purpose, programs, and stakeholders.
- *Part 2: Agency Public Communications.* You will log on to Regulations.gov and find a regulation on a topic that is of interest to your agency. It can be a current proposed rule that is going through the rulemaking process or an older regulation that has already been finalized. You will then summarize the issue the regulation addresses, identify key concerns and comments, and propose alternatives.
- *Part 3: Agency Burden Reduction.* Burden reduction can improve the efficiency of government programs. In this stage of the project, you will select a service or program your agency administers and identify potential administrative burdens associated with it. In a detailed brief, you will outline how the administrative burdens in the service or program selected affect individuals trying to access your service or program.
- *Part 4: Agency Personnel.* Surveys of organizational climate and employee satisfaction can be critical tools for public managers seeking to improve organizational morale. In the final stage of the project, you will be working with data from the Federal Employee Viewpoint Survey (FEVS). You will identify key questions in the FEVS data, compare your agency's performance with other similar agencies, and observe trends over time. Your findings will culminate in a brief documenting a series of recommendations for your agency's leadership to improve employee performance and satisfaction. During our final meeting period, each team will present their analysis to the rest of the class.